Digital Cleanup & Declutter

A Reflection on Care for Creation and Simplicity in the Digital Age

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1. Introduction

In our increasingly digitalized lives, much of our time is spent online—sending emails, saving photos, sharing files, and streaming videos. Yet we rarely pause to consider that all this "invisible" activity consumes very real energy and resources. The idea of a **Digital Cleanup Day** or **Digital Declutter** invites us to reflect on our online habits, care for our common home, and rediscover simplicity.

"Digital Declutter" means intentionally organising, deleting, and simplifying our digital environment—clearing old emails, unused files, and unnecessary data from our devices and cloud storage. While it seems small, these actions have measurable impacts on both the environment and our spiritual well-being.

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2. The Ecological Impact of Digital Clutter

a. The Hidden Carbon Footprint

Every email, search, or cloud file is stored and processed in **data centres** that run continuously, consuming enormous electricity for both operation and cooling systems. According to *The Shift Project* (France), the digital sector accounts for **3.7% of global greenhouse gas emissions**—roughly equal to the airline industry's share[1].

Each email (approximately 75 KB) requires energy to be stored and transmitted through servers. The internet uses an average of **5 kWh of electricity to support 1 GB of data transfer**[2]. If **10,000 students delete 20 emails** each (75 KB × 20 × 10,000 = 15 GB), we save roughly **75 kWh of electricity**, equivalent to the energy used by a typical refrigerator running for 5 days[3].

"Even the smallest acts, if done with love and awareness, can build a better world." — *Pope Francis, Laudato si'*, §211[4]

b. Our Digital Waste Is Physical

Digital waste is stored in real, physical machines that require rare earth metals, water, and electricity to build and operate. As Pope Francis reminds us, "There is an urgent need to develop policies so that, in the next few years, the emission of carbon dioxide and other highly polluting gases can be drastically reduced" (*Laudato si'*, §26)[5].

Thus, **deleting unneeded digital data** is a practical step of ecological conversion — a concrete way to care for creation and reduce our shared digital carbon footprint.

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3. The Spiritual Context: Simplicity, Stewardship, and Inner Peace

a. Simplicity as Spiritual Freedom

Pope Leo XIII, in *Rerum Novarum* (1891), emphasized human dignity, proper use of material goods, and the moral order of social life[6]. These principles extend naturally into our digital existence today: we are not owners but stewards of both material and technological resources.

When our digital lives become overfilled—with distractions, files, and noise—we lose interior clarity. True simplicity, as Jesus teaches, is about "seeking first the Kingdom of God" (Matthew 6:33). Digital decluttering can thus mirror the spiritual act of letting go of attachments that weigh us down.

b. Ecological Conversion

Pope Francis introduces the idea of **"ecological conversion"**, a transformation of heart that recognizes God's presence in creation and our responsibility toward it:

"Living our vocation to be protectors of God's handiwork is essential to a life of virtue; it is not an optional or a secondary aspect of our Christian experience." — *Laudato si'*, §217[7]

Decluttering our digital world can be an act of ecological conversion — aligning our technological life with our spiritual call to stewardship and simplicity.

c. Interconnectedness and the Common Good

"Everything is interconnected." — *Laudato si'*, §138[8]

Our digital footprints connect us to global systems of energy use, mining, and production. Reducing waste in our inboxes or photo drives may seem insignificant, yet it contributes to the **common good**—less demand for energy, fewer servers, reduced emissions, and greater solidarity with the poor, who are most affected by climate change.

4. Reflection and Sharing Questions

1. What aspects of my digital life feel cluttered, disordered, or distracting?
2. How might my online habits reflect my inner life—my values, priorities, or attachments?
3. In what ways can I express care for creation through small digital actions?
4. How can digital simplicity help me experience more peace and focus in prayer, study, or relationships?
5. What spiritual meaning can I find in deleting unnecessary data or organizing my files?

5. Practical Actions

✅ **Delete old emails and files** — start with 20 today.
✅ **Unsubscribe** from unread newsletters.
✅ **Empty your trash folders** and duplicate backups.
✅ **Turn off automatic cloud uploads** for unnecessary apps.
✅ **Schedule a monthly "digital cleanup"** with friends, classmates, or community members.
✅ **Pray before and after the cleanup**, offering it as a small act of care for God's creation.

"May our hearts be uncluttered, our minds clear, and our actions reflect your care, O Lord, for the beauty of your creation."
— *Digital Cleanup Prayer* (adapted from *Laudato si'*)

6. Conclusion

Digital decluttering is not just a technical exercise; it is a moral and spiritual practice. It invites us to live more consciously, humbly, and responsibly in a connected world. As disciples, we are called to integrate faith with every aspect of life—including our relationship with technology.
Let us begin with one small act: deleting 20 unnecessary emails this week. In doing so, we lighten not only our devices—but also our souls.

📚 Endnotes & References

📖 Bibliography

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Footnotes

1. *The Shift Project (2019). Lean ICT: Towards Digital Sobriety*. Paris. Available at: https://theshiftproject.org/en/article/lean-ict-our-new-report/ ↩
2. *Carbon Literacy Project (2021).* "The Carbon Footprint of the Internet." https://carbonliteracy.com ↩
3. U.S. Department of Energy, Appliance Energy Use Database, 2022. ↩
4. Pope Francis, *Laudato si'* (2015), §211. Vatican Press. https://www.vatican.va ↩
5. *Laudato si'*, §26. ↩
6. Pope Leo XIII, *Rerum Novarum* (1891), §§35–36. ↩
7. *Laudato si'*, §217. ↩
8. *Laudato si'*, §138. ↩